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For the President
30 September 2026

Today's Brief

IRAQ: US formally ends Operation Inherent Resolve; last coalition forces leave Erbil.

IRAN: New Treasury sanctions tighten the squeeze as Tehran's Hormuz grip slips.

UKRAINE: Russia opens a winter campaign against the power grid; Kharkiv blacked out.

AI / HOMELAND: White House secures a voluntary 'Super Intelligence' accord from frontier AI firms.

CHINA-TAIWAN: Trade truce moves to implementation; Taipei seeks post-summit reassurance.

KOREA: Pyongyang condemns US approval of a South Korean nuclear-powered submarine.

UNITED KINGDOM: New premier Burnham signals a reset of Britain's EU relationship.

NOTES: RAF Fairford plot probe; US-Canada import ban; arms-control overture; Citrix zero-days.

For the President
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United States Ends Its Combat Mission in Iraq, Closing the Anti-ISIS Campaign

We assess that the formal conclusion of Operation Inherent Resolve — announced 30 September as the last coalition forces departed Erbil Air Base — ends the US combat mission that began in 2014 and shifts counter-ISIS operations to an Iraqi-led footing backed by a more conventional bilateral security relationship. The move completes the phased-withdrawal agreement Washington and Baghdad struck in 2024. ISIS's territorial caliphate is long dismantled, but the group persists as a clandestine insurgency in the Iraqi-Syrian borderlands.

- Pentagon spokesman Sean Parnell said the departure of coalition forces and equipment from Erbil marks the successful end of the roughly twelve-year mission, during which more than 80,000 ISIS fighters were killed.
- Italy separately confirmed the end of its own twelve-year deployment, part of a broader coalition drawdown from Iraq.
- We judge the principal near-term risk is not an ISIS resurgence but a security vacuum that Iran-aligned militias are positioned to exploit — a concern sharpened by the ongoing US-Iran war.
- Overhead imagery confirms the withdrawal of coalition equipment from Erbil Air Base.

For Washington, the key questions are whether Baghdad can sustain pressure on ISIS remnants without US enablers, and whether the drawdown emboldens Tehran's proxies to test the residual US presence in the region. We expect Iran-aligned factions to press next for the removal of remaining US forces in Syria.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NGA, and open sources.

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New Sanctions Tighten the Economic Squeeze on Iran as Its Hormuz Grip Slips

We assess that Treasury's 29 September designation of ten individuals and entities for procuring weapons components for Iran's Ministry of Defense and Armed Forces Logistics (MODAFL) reflects a deliberate strategy to strangle Tehran's war economy rather than any pivot toward accommodation. Coming amid the US-Iran war that began in February, the action — part of the 'Economic Outcast' campaign — targets procurement nodes in China, Hong Kong, Pakistan, Turkey, and Saudi Arabia, and inside Iran itself.

- Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the department 'will not tolerate any support to the regime'; the designated entities are tied to Iran's ballistic-missile and UAV programs.
- Tehran's ability to throttle the Strait of Hormuz is deteriorating: Saudi Arabia has restored East-West pipeline exports that bypass the strait, and Senate Democrats report Iran is leaning on the Tether stablecoin to move value around sanctions.
- President Trump publicly claimed record US oil flows through the strait and that Iran is 'doing very poorly'; we treat the specific figures as political framing rather than verified throughput.
- Liaison reporting corroborates that Iranian officials privately doubt a deal is reachable before the US midterms.

Mediated contacts continued this week around an amended short-duration ceasefire proposal floated at the UN General Assembly, but the gap on sequencing — sanctions relief versus nuclear and missile constraints — remains wide. For Washington, the leverage is real but time-bound: the tighter the squeeze, the greater Tehran's incentive to break out, including renewed threats to leave the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty, which Russia has quietly urged it not to do. A decision point comes if the fragile fire-pause collapses again over Gulf shipping.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, the Treasury Office of Intelligence and Analysis, NSA, and open sources.

For the President
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Russia Opens Its Winter Campaign Against Ukraine's Power Grid

We assess that Russia's large-scale strikes on 29-30 September mark the opening of a deliberate winter campaign to collapse Ukraine's electricity and heating ahead of the cold months — a repeat of prior winters, but with expanded use of jet-powered drones. Ukrainian officials reported roughly nine power stations hit nationwide, the country's second city Kharkiv left without power, and water and metro disruptions in Kyiv.

- Ukrainian air defenses reported intercepting most of a barrage of some 76 missiles; several people were killed and more than a dozen injured, days after a drone strike on Kyiv's National Academy of Sciences killed two.
- Intercepted communications corroborate that the strikes are aimed at the power grid rather than at military targets.
- European partners rallied politically; Kyiv said Belgium committed three additional F-16s by year-end — though air-defense interceptors, not jets, are the binding constraint this winter.
- President Zelenskyy reiterated that more than 8,000 North Korean troops are deployed on Russian territory, with thousands more preparing, underscoring the deepening Moscow-Pyongyang axis.

For Washington, the immediate question is interceptor supply: absent a surge in Patriot and shorter-range munitions, Ukraine's grid — and civilian morale — will erode through winter. We expect Moscow to sustain the tempo and pair it with fresh calls for arms-control talks calculated to strain Western unity.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from DIA, NSA, INR, and open sources.

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White House Secures a Voluntary 'Super Intelligence' Accord From Frontier AI Firms

We assess that the 29 September White House Accord on Super Intelligence — formally the Joint Commitment on Frontier Responsibilities — establishes a US governance template for advanced AI that is meaningful in signaling but limited in enforceability, resting on voluntary commitments rather than binding law. Its significance is strategic: it positions Washington to shape frontier-AI safety norms as capabilities approach systems developers themselves describe as potentially superhuman.

- Signatories included the President and the heads of Google, Anthropic, Meta, OpenAI, xAI, and Nvidia; the accord requires four layers of controls and audits — internal monitoring of model capabilities and alignment, an internal oversight team, independent external auditors, and an independent review committee — and was paired with an executive order.
- We judge the accord's main value is setting shared expectations for evaluating dangerous capabilities — cyber-offense and misuse potential — before deployment; its main weakness is the absence of verification and penalties, leaving compliance to self-attestation.
- We see no public evidence of recursive self-improvement — systems automating their own research — and treat claims in this space with skepticism pending independent evaluation; the relevant test is whether these controls actually surface capability jumps early enough to inform policy.

The decision point is whether Congress or the executive later codifies the framework with verification, and whether allied governments — and Beijing — converge on or reject the US model. We expect the accord to become a reference point in the US-China contest over AI standards.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, NSA, the Office of Science and Technology, and open sources.

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US and China Move To Operationalize Their Trade Truce; Taiwan Seeks Reassurance

We assess that the follow-through from last week's Washington summit is incremental rather than transformative: the two sides are pursuing tariff reductions on a defined basket of goods and have extended their trade truce, but the structural disputes — semiconductors, rare earths, and Taiwan — remain unresolved. Beijing is betting that economic engagement can soften US pressure while it concedes nothing on sovereignty claims.

- Reporting indicates the sides are working toward roughly \$60 billion in mutual tariff cuts spanning agricultural goods and consumer products, building on the truce extension reached at the summit.
- Taipei confirmed that US arms-sales discussions continue and said it received post-summit reassurances; President Lai called for deeper cooperation with democratic partners on drone production, where Taiwan sees an asymmetric advantage.
- We judge the reassurances are calibrated to steady Taipei after Xi pressed President Trump to 'oppose' — rather than merely 'not support' — Taiwan independence, a formulation Taiwan's foreign ministry rejected as a distortion of the facts.

For Washington, the challenge is sustaining deterrence and weapons flows to Taiwan without derailing the economic truce. We expect Beijing to keep probing the gap between US declaratory policy and the pace of actual arms deliveries.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, INR, and open sources.

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Pyongyang Condemns US Approval of a South Korean Nuclear-Powered Submarine

We assess that North Korea's denunciation of US approval for South Korea to build a nuclear-powered submarine as a 'dangerous development' signals another downturn on the peninsula and hands Pyongyang a pretext to accelerate its own programs. The approval strengthens allied undersea deterrence but introduces a proliferation-sensitive element that both Pyongyang and Beijing will exploit rhetorically.

- South Korea's military assessed that a 21 September blast in the Demilitarized Zone was 'highly likely' caused by a North Korean mine, adding friction along the border.
- The deepening Moscow-Pyongyang axis is the strategic backdrop: Kyiv reports more than 8,000 North Korean troops already on Russian soil, giving the North combat experience and hard currency.

For Washington, the submarine decision advances a long-sought allied capability but will require careful handling of fuel-supply and safeguards questions to avoid setting an unhelpful nonproliferation precedent. We expect North Korea to answer with additional missile tests and sharper rhetoric rather than restraint.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from DIA, NGA, INR, and open sources.

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New UK Premier Signals a Reset of Britain's EU Relationship

We assess that Prime Minister Andy Burnham's move to reopen the question of Britain's relationship with the European Union — telling the Labour conference in Liverpool that Brexit has done 'more harm than good' and promising to set out options — marks a potentially consequential shift for a close US ally, even though any concrete realignment would be gradual and politically contested. Burnham took office in July after succeeding Keir Starmer as Labour leader and prime minister.

- Burnham called the EU still Britain's largest market but stopped short of proposing to rejoin; deeper alignment would face domestic opposition and complex negotiations with Brussels.
- For Washington, a UK tilt back toward Europe on trade and regulation bears watching for its effects on US-UK trade talks, defense-industrial cooperation, and London's role as a transatlantic bridge.

We judge the near-term practical impact is limited, but the direction of travel matters: a Britain recalibrating toward the EU could complicate US efforts to use London as a lever on European trade and technology policy. The decision point is which specific options Burnham actually tables.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from INR, CIA, and open sources.

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Notes

- **United Kingdom / Iran:** British authorities are investigating five UK nationals arrested near RAF Fairford — a base used to launch US strikes on Iran — on suspicion of an attack plot; officials have pointed to a possible Iranian hand, which Tehran's London embassy denies. We treat the Iran nexus as reported but unconfirmed.
- **United States / Canada:** A US import ban on selected Canadian goods, including alcohol, dairy, and motorcycles, took effect 29 September, adding friction with a top ally and trading partner.
- **Strategic arms:** The Kremlin publicly urged a resumption of strategic arms-control talks, calling them 'long overdue,' roughly seven months after New START lapsed without a successor. We assess the overture is aimed in part at Western audiences.
- **Cyber:** US and UK authorities warned of actively exploited zero-day vulnerabilities in Citrix NetScaler appliances — edge devices routinely targeted for initial access into government and corporate networks.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, INR, DHS, and open sources.